

HER TAKE

"Real leadership is not about power or position. It is about earning trust and standing by people, especially in their most vulnerable moments"

For Merin Joseph, excellence has been a constant. Brought up in New Delhi, with roots in Kerala, she was an outstanding student at St Stephen's College, winning multiple academic prizes before earning a Chevening Scholarship to pursue a Master's in Public Policy at the University of Oxford's Blavatnik School of Government.

It was her father, Dr Joseph Abraham, a former principal advisor to the Government of India, who persuaded her to take the civil services examination. She cleared it on her first attempt at just 22. Joining the Kerala cadre of the Indian Police Service (IPS) in 2012, Merin first came into the spotlight as Assistant Superintendent of Police in Munnar, where she helped steer the police response to the Pombilai Orumai agitation by thousands of women plantation workers, facilitating a peaceful resolution through dialogue with the management of the Tatas-owned enterprise.

Over the past 14 years, Merin has built a career marked by crisis leadership and a commitment to justice. She received the Chief Minister's Medal for her role in coordinating rescue operations during Kerala's devastating 2018 floods, and later earned the state police chief's Badge of Honour for her role in tracking missing women and children. Her crowning achievement came as Kollam City Police Commissioner, when she revived a pending rape case involving a 13-year-old girl, coordinated with the CBI, Interpol and Saudi authorities, and personally led a team to Riyadh in 2019 to bring the absconding accused back to India to face trial. He was later convicted and sentenced to life imprisonment.

"There wasn't one defining moment that changed my life," she says. "Every interaction with people, every difficult decision, and every challenge in uniform has reinforced why I chose public service." She credits former IPS officer Kiran Bedi as a lasting inspiration, admiring her courage, integrity and willingness to challenge the status quo. Her own message to young women is equally unequivocal: "Never underestimate the power of your own voice. You don't have to fit into someone else's definition of success. Dream!" ■

—Jeemon Jacob